

THE GUIDE · BAND OF ONE

The Solo Admin *Playbook*

A practical system for handling client admin with AI,
for freelancers, consultants and coaches who run the
whole show.

- Admin audit & priority scoring
- Safe AI setup: brief, voice, privacy
- Six client workflows with templates
- Getting paid: a 5-stage reminder system
- SOPs, light automation & weekly review



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How to use this playbook

You run a service business on your own. You're good at the work clients pay for. You're less excited about everything around it: replying to inquiries, writing proposals, onboarding, status updates, invoices, follow-ups, and the weekly scramble to remember who needs what.

This playbook gives you a **complete, practical system** for that admin, using AI where it genuinely helps and simple templates where AI would be overkill. It is built for people who don't want another subscription and don't want to become automation engineers.

What you'll have when you finish

- **An admin map** of your business: every recurring task, how long it takes, and what to do about it.
- **An AI workspace set up safely**: a reusable business brief, a voice profile, and privacy habits that protect your clients.
- **Six client workflows**, each with a checklist, templates and prompts: inquiries and discovery, proposals, onboarding, delivery communication, getting paid, and offboarding.
- **A starter SOP library** so you stop reinventing your own processes.
- **A 45-minute weekly admin review** that keeps the whole system running.

How long it takes

Plan on **about three hours spread across a week**. The final section, *Your next seven days*, is a day-by-day implementation plan. You don't need to finish everything before you benefit: the onboarding and getting-paid workflows can be used the same day you read them.

What you need

You need	Notes
Any AI chat assistant	ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini or Microsoft Copilot. Free tiers are enough for everything in this book.
Email with a "templates" or "snippets" feature	Gmail, Outlook and most email apps have one.
A spreadsheet	<i>The Client Desk</i> workbook (sold separately) is designed to match this book, but any spreadsheet works.
30 minutes of honesty	For the admin audit in Chapter 2.

How the three Band of One products fit together

Product	Role
The Solo Admin Playbook (this book)	The <i>method</i> : what to do, in what order, and why
The Client Desk (workbook)	The <i>tracker</i> : clients, pipeline, invoices, follow-up dates and your admin audit, calculated for you
The Band of One Prompt Library	The <i>toolbox</i> : 100 detailed prompts. Prompt IDs like <code>PR0P-01</code> in this book point to it

Every prompt you need is printed in full inside this book, so the Playbook works on its own.

A WORD ON WHAT THIS BOOK IS NOT

This is an educational guide, not legal, tax or financial advice. Contract terms, late fees and tax obligations vary by country and state. Where money or contracts are involved, the book tells you what to ask a professional. AI tools also change quickly. The workflows here are deliberately tool-agnostic, and any tool facts are dated.

The admin problem in a business of one

IN THIS CHAPTER

Why admin swallows so much of a solo business's week, what the evidence actually says, and the three levels of fixing it (only one of which involves "automation").

Admin is a real cost, not a character flaw

If admin feels like it's eating your week, you are not imagining it. In a survey of 251 U.S. entrepreneurs commissioned by the virtual-assistant company Time etc (September 2023), respondents reported spending **an average of 36% of their work week on administrative tasks**. In a typical week, 44% said they create invoices and 27% chase late payers.^[1]

Late payment is a measurable problem too. The freelance software company Bonsai analyzed invoicing data from more than 100,000 freelancers over three years and found that **29% of invoices were paid at least one day late**. Larger invoices were more likely to be late than small ones.^[2]

Both sources are companies with something to sell, so treat the exact numbers as directional. But the pattern matches what solo business owners say in public communities again and again: the work is fine; the *wrapping* around the work is exhausting.

Most small businesses haven't cracked AI yet, and that's an advantage

The U.S. Census Bureau's Business Trends and Outlook Survey found that between December 2025 and May 2026, overall business AI use "hovered between 17% and 20%", and **fewer than 20% of firms with four or fewer employees reported using AI**. Use among firms with fewer than 20 employees didn't change significantly over that period.^[3]

In other words, if you set up a sensible AI-assisted system now, you're early, not late.

The three levels of fixing admin

Most "automate your business" advice jumps straight to complicated tools. In a business of one, the biggest wins usually come from the first two levels:

Level	What it is	Typical examples	Effort
1. Decide once	Templates, checklists and standard answers, with no AI needed	Onboarding checklist; standard payment terms; saved email replies	Low
2. Draft with AI	AI turns your notes into a first draft that you edit	Proposals from call notes; weekly updates; meeting summaries; SOPs	Low–medium
3. Automate	Software triggers actions without you	Form → spreadsheet → auto-reply; invoice reminders sent by your invoicing tool	Medium

The rule of this book: move a task up a level only when the level below it is working. A great template beats a flaky automation every time.

What AI is (and isn't) good at in your admin

AI is good at	AI is bad at, or risky for
Turning messy notes into clear drafts	Knowing facts about your client it wasn't told
Matching a tone you describe or demonstrate	Making commitments on your behalf
Summarizing long threads and transcripts	Legal, tax or jurisdiction-specific advice
Producing variations (subject lines, options)	Anything that needs judgment about a relationship
Checking your draft against a checklist	Handling confidential data you haven't cleared to share

THE GOLDEN RULE

AI drafts; you decide. Nothing AI writes goes to a client until you've read it, fixed it, and would be comfortable signing it with your own name. You would be.

Run your admin audit

IN THIS CHAPTER

A 30-minute exercise that shows exactly where your admin time goes and which tasks to fix first. Everything else in the book builds on it.

Step 1: List every recurring admin task

Use the prompts below to jog your memory. Aim for 10–25 tasks. Include anything you do more than once a month that isn't the paid work itself.

- **Getting clients:** replying to inquiries, discovery calls, proposals, follow-ups, contracts.
- **Starting projects:** welcome emails, questionnaires, folders, kickoff scheduling, deposits.
- **During projects:** status updates, meeting notes, feedback rounds, scope questions, file sharing.
- **Money:** invoices, payment reminders, receipts, expense logging, price quotes.
- **Finishing:** handover documents, testimonial requests, referrals, archiving.
- **Running the business:** scheduling, social posts, newsletter, bookkeeping prep, tool subscriptions.

Step 2: Estimate frequency and minutes

For each task, write how many times a month you do it and roughly how many minutes it takes each time. Estimates are fine. You'll refine them later.

Step 3: Score repeatability and risk

- **Repeatability (1–3):** 3 = almost identical every time; 2 = similar with some variation; 1 = different every time.
- **Risk (1–3):** 1 = low stakes (a mistake is easy to fix); 2 = medium (money, client data, deadlines); 3 = high (legal, sensitive or relationship-critical).

Step 4: Calculate the priority score

Priority score = (times per month × minutes each) × repeatability ÷ risk

High scores mean frequent, time-consuming, repeatable and low-risk tasks: the best candidates to fix first. *The Client Desk* workbook calculates this for you on its **Admin Audit** tab.

Step 5: Choose a decision for each task

Decision	Use when
Eliminate	Nobody would notice if you stopped (e.g., a report no client reads)
Template	The task is nearly identical every time
AI draft	The structure repeats but the content changes (proposals, updates)
Automate	It's rule-based, frequent, low-risk, and already templated
Keep human	High risk, high judgment, or relationship-critical

WORKED EXAMPLE: SAM'S AUDIT (FICTIONAL)

Sam is a **fictional** freelance web designer we'll follow through the book. Sam has four active clients. Sam's first audit:

Task	Times/mo	Min each	Min/mo	Repeat (1-3)	Risk (1-3)	Priority	Decision
Weekly client updates	16	20	320	3	1	960	Template + AI draft
Social media posts	8	30	240	2	1	480	AI-assisted repurposing
Replying to inquiries	8	15	120	3	1	360	Template + AI draft
Onboarding emails & setup	2	60	120	3	1	360	Checklist + templates
Writing proposals	3	90	270	2	2	270	AI draft from call notes
Meeting notes & follow-ups	12	15	180	3	2	270	AI summary (redacted)
Sending invoices	6	15	90	3	2	135	Template in invoicing tool
Chasing late payments	3	20	60	3	2	90	Reminder sequence

Task	Times/mo	Min each	Min/mo	Repeat (1-3)	Risk (1-3)	Priority	Decision
Total			1,400 (≈23 h)				

Sam's biggest surprise: the "small" weekly updates add up to more time than proposals. They also score highest, because they're identical in structure and low-risk. That's where Sam starts.

ABOUT TIME SAVINGS

We can't promise how much time you'll save. It depends on your clients, tools and habits. Measure instead: re-estimate the minutes for your top five tasks after two weeks of using the new workflows, and compare.

Your audit worksheet

ADMIN AUDIT

List your recurring tasks, then score them. Use the formula above or *The Client Desk* Admin Audit tab.

Task	Times/mo	Min each	Min/mo	Repeat	Risk	Priority	Decision

My top three tasks to fix first:

Set up your AI workspace safely

IN THIS CHAPTER

Pick an assistant, protect client confidentiality, and create two reusable documents (your **business brief** and your **voice profile**) that make every AI draft sound more like you.

Pick one assistant and stick with it

For admin work, the major general-purpose assistants (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Microsoft Copilot) are all capable. Free tiers are enough to start. Choose based on what you already use: if your email and documents live in Google Workspace or Microsoft 365, the matching assistant may integrate more smoothly. What matters most is using **one** assistant consistently so your saved instructions and habits build up.

Protect your clients' information

Before you paste anything about a client into an AI tool, do three things once:

1. **Check your settings.** Most assistants let you control whether your conversations are used to improve their models. In ChatGPT, this is the "Improve the model for everyone" toggle under **Settings → Data controls**; when it's off, new conversations aren't used for training.^[4] Anthropic's consumer Claude plans let you choose whether chats are used to improve Claude, and you can change it any time in **Privacy Settings**.^[5] Other assistants have similar controls. Look them up and make a deliberate choice.
2. **Check your client agreements.** Some contracts and NDAs restrict sharing client information with third-party services. If yours do, use redaction (below) or don't use AI for that client's material.
3. **Adopt a redaction habit.** Replace names, company names, email addresses, phone numbers, financial details and anything sensitive with placeholders before you paste.

REDACTION CHECKLIST, BEFORE YOU PASTE

- ☐ Client and company names → [CLIENT] , [COMPANY]
- ☐ Emails, phone numbers, addresses → removed
- ☐ Bank, card or tax ID numbers → never pasted
- ☐ Health, legal or HR details about individuals → removed
- ☐ Passwords, API keys, login links → never pasted
- ☐ Anything under NDA → removed, or AI not used

SET-03 • REDACTION CHECK BEFORE PASTING

I'm about to paste text into an AI assistant. Act as a careful privacy reviewer. Scan the text between the triple quotes and list every item that could identify a person or company or expose sensitive data (names, emails, phone numbers, addresses, account numbers, prices tied to named clients, health/legal/HR details, passwords or links with tokens). Then return a redacted version that replaces each item with a clear placeholder like [CLIENT NAME] or [INVOICE AMOUNT]. Don't change anything else. ""[PASTE TEXT]""

Tip: if you run this check inside the same assistant, the text has already been shared with it. Use it to catch things you missed while you learn the habit, or run it on a version you've already partly redacted.

Create your business brief (once, reuse forever)

AI drafts are generic when the AI knows nothing about you. A **business brief** is a one-page description you paste at the start of a conversation, or save into your assistant's custom instructions, project or "memory" feature.

SET-01 • BUSINESS BRIEF BUILDER

Help me write a one-page "business brief" I can give an AI assistant before asking for help with client admin. Interview me with one question at a time (wait for each answer) covering: what I do and for whom; my 2-4 core services and typical project size; how I like to work (communication hours, response times, meeting preferences); my payment terms and policies; phrases or promises I never want used; and three examples of great client outcomes (described generally, no client names). When we're done, output the brief in this format: ## Who I am, ## Services, ## Ideal clients, ## How I work, ## Policies, ## Tone and words to avoid. Keep it under 450 words.

EXCERPT FROM SAM'S BUSINESS BRIEF (FICTIONAL)

Who I am: Independent web designer (Squarespace and Webflow) for local professional-service firms. **How I work:** Replies within one business day; client calls Tue–Thu; one round of consolidated feedback per milestone. **Policies:** 50% deposit to start; invoices due in 14 days; out-of-scope requests quoted separately before work begins. **Tone:** Friendly, direct, no jargon. Never promise launch dates before content is received.

Create your voice profile

Your clients hired *you*, so your emails should still sound like you. Collect **three to five emails you've written that you're happy with** (redacted), and ask your assistant to describe your style.

SET-02 · VOICE PROFILE FROM WRITING SAMPLES

Below are [NUMBER] emails I wrote to clients (names removed). Analyze my writing style and produce a "voice profile" I can reuse in future prompts. Include: typical sentence length; greeting and sign-off habits; level of formality (1-5); words and phrases I use often; things I never do (e.g., exclamation marks, emojis, corporate phrases); how I deliver bad news; and 3 short "do this / not that" examples. Keep it under 250 words and don't invent traits that aren't in the samples. ""[PASTE 3-5 REDACTED EMAILS]""

Save both documents in one place. From now on, the most effective prompt starter is:

"Here is my business brief and voice profile: [paste]. Using them, ..."

The four-check review (use on every draft)

Before any AI-drafted message leaves your outbox, check:

1. **Facts:** Are dates, prices, names and deliverables correct?
2. **Promises:** Did the draft commit you to anything you didn't intend (deadlines, extra work, guarantees)?
3. **Tone:** Does it sound like you, and like how you treat this client?
4. **Specifics:** Does it mention something only *this* client would recognize? If not, add one line that does.

The client lifecycle system

IN THIS CHAPTER

The map that organizes the rest of the book. Each stage of a client relationship has predictable admin, so each stage gets a checklist, templates and prompts.



Stage	The admin that happens here	Your system (chapter)
1. Inquiry	Reply fast, qualify, book a call	Inquiry reply template + booking link (Ch. 5)
2. Discovery	Prepare, take notes, follow up	Call prep sheet + notes-to-summary prompt (Ch. 5)
3. Proposal	Scope, price, send, follow up	Proposal structure + AI draft from notes (Ch. 6)
4. Onboarding	Agreement, deposit, welcome, questionnaire, kickoff	30-minute onboarding checklist (Ch. 7)
5. Delivery	Updates, meetings, feedback, scope changes	Weekly update template + meeting summaries (Ch. 8)
6. Payment	Invoice, remind, record	Reminder cadence + templates (Ch. 9)
7. Offboarding	Handover, testimonial, referral, archive	Offboarding checklist (Ch. 10)

Track the stage of every client in one place. *The Client Desk* has a **Clients & Pipeline** tab with a stage dropdown and a "next action date" column. Any spreadsheet with the columns *Client*, *Stage*, *Next action*, *Next action date*, *Project value* and *Notes* works too.

Workflow 1: Inquiries and discovery calls

IN THIS CHAPTER

Reply to new inquiries within one business day with a template you personalize in two minutes. Walk into discovery calls prepared, and send a follow-up summary the same day.

The inquiry reply

Speed and clarity beat polish here. Your reply should (1) thank them and show you read their message, (2) answer the one question they asked, (3) ask two or three qualifying questions, and (4) offer a clear next step.

TEMPLATE: INQUIRY REPLY

Subject: Re: [their subject], next steps

Hi [NAME],

Thanks for reaching out about [ONE-LINE SUMMARY OF THEIR REQUEST]. [ONE SENTENCE THAT SHOWS YOU READ IT, e.g., "Moving from Wix to Squarespace before your spring launch makes sense."]

To see if I'm the right fit, could you share:

1. [QUALIFYING QUESTION 1, e.g., "Your ideal launch date?"]
2. [QUALIFYING QUESTION 2, e.g., "Roughly how many pages?"]
3. [BUDGET RANGE QUESTION, e.g., "A budget range you have in mind?"]

If it's easier to talk, you can book a 20-minute call here: [BOOKING LINK].

[SIGN-OFF]

LEAD-01 • REPLY TO A NEW INQUIRY

Here is my business brief and voice profile: [PASTE]. A potential client sent this inquiry (redacted): ""[PASTE INQUIRY]"". Draft a reply under 150 words that: thanks them and references one specific detail from their message; answers any direct question they asked (if I haven't given you the answer, write [NEED INFO] instead of guessing); asks the 2-3 most useful qualifying questions for my services; and ends with my booking link [BOOKING LINK]. Match my voice profile. Don't mention prices unless they asked and my brief includes them.

Qualifying questions bank

Pick two or three per inquiry. You don't need them all.

- What prompted you to look for help now?
- What does success look like three months after this project is done?
- Is there a date this needs to be finished by, and what drives that date?
- Who else is involved in decisions?
- Have you worked with a [YOUR PROFESSION] before? What went well or badly?
- Do you have a budget range in mind?

Discovery call prep (10 minutes)

DISC-02 • DISCOVERY CALL PREP SHEET

I have a discovery call with a potential client. Here is what I know (redacted): ""[INQUIRY + ANY PUBLIC INFO ABOUT THEIR BUSINESS]"". My services: [SERVICES]. Create a one-page call prep sheet with: (1) a 2-sentence summary of what they seem to want; (2) 5 open questions to uncover goals, constraints and decision process; (3) 3 likely objections or risks and how I might address them; (4) what I need to learn to scope the project; (5) a proposed call agenda for [LENGTH] minutes. Flag any assumptions you're making.

After the call: summary + next steps (same day)

Record your notes during the call (or use a meeting transcription tool **only with the client's knowledge and consent**). Then turn them into a follow-up email.

DISC-05 · CALL NOTES → SUMMARY + NEXT STEPS EMAIL

Here are my rough notes from a discovery call (redacted): ""[NOTES]"". Using my voice profile [PASTE], write a follow-up email that: thanks them; summarizes their goals, constraints and timeline in 3-5 bullets using their words where possible; lists open questions; states the next step and date (e.g., "I'll send a proposal by [DATE]"); and stays under 200 words. After the email, separately list anything in my notes that is ambiguous or that I should clarify before writing a proposal.

WORKFLOW 1 CHECKLIST

- ☐ Inquiry reply template saved in my email app
- ☐ Booking link created (20–30 minute slot)
- ☐ Qualifying questions chosen
- ☐ Call prep prompt saved
- ☐ Follow-up summary sent the same day as the call
- ☐ Client added to my tracker at stage "Discovery" with a next-action date

Workflow 2: Proposals that don't sound generic

IN THIS CHAPTER

A proposal structure that sells outcomes, an AI prompt that drafts it from your call notes, a scope-exclusions list that prevents scope creep, and a polite follow-up schedule.

The seven-part proposal

1. **Their situation**, in their words (from your call summary).
2. **Outcomes**: what will be different when you're done.
3. **Scope**: deliverables as a numbered list.
4. **Not included**: explicit exclusions and assumptions.
5. **Timeline**: milestones, and what you need from them to hit each one.
6. **Investment**: price, payment schedule, and what's included. Many service providers offer two or three options; if you do, make the differences obvious.
7. **Next step**: exactly how to say yes (reply, sign, pay deposit).

PROP-01 • PROPOSAL DRAFT FROM DISCOVERY NOTES

Here is my business brief [PASTE], my voice profile [PASTE], and my discovery call summary (redacted): ""[SUMMARY]"". Draft a proposal using this structure: 1) Your situation (3-4 sentences using the client's words), 2) Outcomes (3-5 bullets), 3) Scope (numbered deliverables), 4) Not included (5-8 bullets), 5) Timeline (milestones with client dependencies), 6) Investment: [PRICE / OPTIONS I'LL PROVIDE]. Use exactly my prices and payment terms and don't invent numbers. 7) Next step. Keep it under 700 words, plain language, no buzzwords. Mark anything you had to assume with [CHECK].

DON'T LET AI PRICE YOUR WORK

AI doesn't know your costs, your market or your capacity. Set the price yourself, then paste it in. If a draft contains any number you didn't provide, delete it.

The scope-exclusions list (your best scope-creep defense)

Most scope creep starts with an assumption nobody wrote down. Keep a master list of common exclusions for your service and include the relevant ones in every proposal.

PROP-06 • SCOPE EXCLUSIONS & ASSUMPTIONS LIST

I'm a [PROFESSION] and this project includes: [DELIVERABLES]. List 10 things clients commonly assume are included in this kind of project but often aren't (e.g., extra revision rounds, copywriting, stock photos, hosting, training, ongoing support). For each, write one plain-language line for a "Not included" section and, where useful, the add-on I could offer instead. Then list 5 assumptions about the client's responsibilities (content, feedback times, access) that I should state in the proposal.

Follow-up schedule

A polite, predictable follow-up is not pushy; it's professional. A simple cadence:

When	Message
Day of sending	Proposal + one-line summary of the next step
Day 3	"Any questions I can answer?" (one sentence)
Day 7	Offer a 15-minute call to walk through options
Day 14	Close the loop: "I'll assume the timing isn't right. Happy to revisit."

This cadence is a suggested starting point, not a researched benchmark. Adjust it to your clients and industry.

WORKFLOW 2 CHECKLIST

- ☐ Proposal template (7 parts) saved as a document
- ☐ Master exclusions list written for my main service
- ☐ Prices and payment terms decided by me (not AI)
- ☐ Follow-up dates added to my tracker when a proposal is sent

Workflow 3: Onboarding in 30 minutes

IN THIS CHAPTER

A checklist that turns "yes!" into a smooth start: agreement, deposit, welcome email, intake questionnaire and kickoff. Most of it is Level 1 (decide once); AI helps personalize.

The onboarding checklist

NEW CLIENT ONBOARDING

- ☐ Agreement/contract sent and signed (use a professionally reviewed template)
- ☐ Deposit invoice sent (terms per your agreement)
- ☐ Welcome email sent (template below)
- ☐ Intake questionnaire sent
- ☐ Kickoff call scheduled
- ☐ Shared folder created with a consistent structure
- ☐ Tracker updated: stage = Onboarding, next action + date
- ☐ Communication norms shared (response times, channels, feedback rounds)
- ☐ Calendar blocked for the first milestone

The welcome email

TEMPLATE: WELCOME EMAIL

Subject: Welcome aboard: what happens next

Hi [NAME],

I'm really glad we're working together on [PROJECT]. Here's what happens over the next [TIMEFRAME]:

1. **Paperwork:** your agreement and deposit invoice are in separate emails. Work starts once both are complete.
2. **Questionnaire:** please fill in this short form by [DATE]: [LINK]. It takes about [MINUTES] minutes.
3. **Kickoff:** pick a time for our kickoff call: [BOOKING LINK].

How we'll work together: I reply to emails within [RESPONSE TIME] on [WORKING DAYS]. For feedback, I'll ask for one consolidated set of comments per milestone so nothing gets lost.

Any questions, just reply here.

[SIGN-OFF]

ONB-01 • WELCOME EMAIL

Using my business brief and voice profile [PASTE], write a welcome email for a new client (redacted details: "[PROJECT, TIMELINE, LINKS]"). Include: a warm opening that references the project; a numbered "what happens next" list (agreement, deposit, questionnaire link, kickoff booking link); my communication norms from the brief; and a friendly close. Under 220 words. Use only the links and dates I provide. Use [NEED INFO] for anything missing.

The intake questionnaire

Ask only what you'll actually use. Send it as a form (Google Forms, Microsoft Forms, Tally or similar) so answers land in one place.

ONB-03 • INTAKE QUESTIONNAIRE BUILDER

I'm a [PROFESSION] starting a [PROJECT TYPE] for a client. Create an intake questionnaire of 10-15 questions grouped under: Goals & success measures; Audience/customers; Brand & preferences; Content & assets they'll provide; Access & logistics; Communication & approvals. For each question, note why I need it (one line) and mark it Required or Optional. Avoid questions I could answer myself from their website. End with a "Anything else we should know?" question.

Level 3 option: automate the hand-offs

Once the checklist works manually, a free automation tier can remove the copy-pasting. For example: *form submission* → *new row in your spreadsheet* → *notification to you*. As of September 2026, Zapier's free plan includes 100 tasks per month with two-step Zaps, and Make's free plan includes up to 1,000 credits per month with 2 active scenarios.^[6,7] Free limits change, so check before building.

WORKFLOW 3 CHECKLIST

- ☐ Onboarding checklist copied into my tracker or task app
- ☐ Welcome email template saved
- ☐ Intake questionnaire built as a form
- ☐ Standard folder structure documented
- ☐ Agreement template reviewed by a professional (one-time)

Workflow 4: Delivery communication

IN THIS CHAPTER

Keep clients confident and informed with a weekly update that takes five minutes, meeting summaries that write themselves, and a calm way to handle scope changes.

The five-minute weekly update

Clients rarely complain about too much clarity. A short, predictable update prevents "just checking in" emails and surfaces problems early.

TEMPLATE: WEEKLY UPDATE

Subject: [PROJECT]: week of [DATE] update

Hi [NAME],

Done this week: [2–4 bullets] **Next week:** [2–3 bullets] **Needed from you:** [items + dates, or "Nothing this week"] **Risks / decisions:** [anything that could affect timeline or budget, or "None"]

[SIGN-OFF]

DEL-01 • WEEKLY CLIENT UPDATE

Turn my rough notes into a weekly client update using this structure: Done this week / Next week / Needed from you (with dates) / Risks or decisions. Notes (redacted): "[NOTES]". Keep it under 150 words, in my voice [VOICE PROFILE]. If my notes mention a delay, state it plainly with the new expected date. Don't soften it into vagueness, and don't invent reasons.

In Sam's (fictional) audit, weekly updates were the highest-scoring task. With a template and this prompt, Sam's process becomes: jot 5 bullets during the week → paste → edit → send.

Meeting notes to action items

DEL-04 · MEETING NOTES → SUMMARY & ACTION ITEMS

Here are notes or a transcript from a client meeting (redacted): ""[NOTES]"". Produce: (1) a 3-sentence summary; (2) decisions made; (3) action items as a table with Owner, Task, Due date (write "TBC" if no date was agreed; don't invent dates); (4) open questions. Then draft a short follow-up email to the client that confirms decisions and action items.

RECORDING AND TRANSCRIPTION

Only record or transcribe calls with the other person's knowledge. Consent rules vary by location. Tell people at the start of the call, and respect a "no".

Handling scope changes without awkwardness

When a client asks for something outside the agreed scope, the professional move is to **acknowledge, clarify, and quote** before doing the work.

DEL-07 · SCOPE CHANGE REQUEST EMAIL

A client asked for something outside our agreed scope. Agreed scope: ""[SCOPE]"". Their request: ""[REQUEST]"". Draft a friendly, confident email that: thanks them for the idea; notes it's outside the current scope (without blaming); offers 2 options, (a) add it now for [PRICE / TIME IMPACT I'LL PROVIDE] or (b) park it for a later phase; and asks them to confirm which option they prefer before I start. Under 170 words, in my voice.

WORKFLOW 4 CHECKLIST

- ☐ Weekly update template saved; reminder set for the same day each week
- ☐ Meeting-summary prompt saved
- ☐ Scope change email template saved
- ☐ Consent line for recording prepared ("Do you mind if I record this for my notes?")

Workflow 5: Getting paid

IN THIS CHAPTER

Set clear payment terms, invoice consistently, and follow up on a predictable schedule with messages that stay friendly but firm. This is the workflow with the most direct effect on your cash flow.

Prevent late payment before it starts

- **Agree terms before work starts.** Put the deposit, schedule and due dates in your agreement.
- **Take a deposit for new clients.** A deposit (commonly a percentage of the project) confirms commitment and funds the first phase.
- **Bill large projects in milestones.** In Bonsai's data, invoices over \$20,000 were about three times more likely to be paid late than invoices under \$100.^[2] Smaller, more frequent invoices reduce the damage when one is late.
- **Use exact due dates.** "Due 14 October" is clearer than "Net 14".
- **Make paying easy.** Include a payment link or clear bank details, the invoice number and a one-line description of what it covers.

EVERY INVOICE INCLUDES

- ☐ Unique invoice number and issue date
- ☐ Your business name and contact details; the client's billing name
- ☐ Clear description of work (and milestone, if relevant)
- ☐ Amount, currency and any tax lines required where you operate
- ☐ Exact due date
- ☐ How to pay (link or details)
- ☐ Late-payment terms **only if they're in your agreement**

LATE FEES AND INTEREST

Whether you can charge late fees or interest, and how much, depends on your contract and your location. Some countries give businesses a statutory right to interest on late business-to-business payments (the UK is one example). Check your local rules and put your terms in writing before you rely on them.

A predictable reminder cadence

Payment providers' guides recommend similar structures: a friendly reminder before the due date, a note on the due date, then progressively firmer messages at roughly one, two and four weeks overdue.^[8,9,10] Here's a version that fits a solo service business:

Stage	When	Tone	Goal
A. Heads-up	3 days before due	Friendly	Prevent "I forgot"
B. Due today	Due date	Friendly	Make paying effortless
C. Gentle nudge	7 days overdue	Polite, direct	Surface any problem
D. Firm follow-up	14 days overdue	Firm, helpful	Offer a plan; set a date
E. Final notice	30 days overdue	Formal	State next steps per your agreement

The Client Desk workbook calculates **days overdue** and the **next reminder stage** for each invoice automatically, so you only need to look at one column during your weekly review.

Reminder templates

A. HEADS-UP (3 DAYS BEFORE)

Subject: Invoice [NUMBER] due [DATE]

Hi [NAME], a quick heads-up that invoice [NUMBER] for [AMOUNT] is due on [DATE]. You can pay here: [LINK]. Thanks!

B. DUE TODAY

Subject: Invoice [NUMBER] is due today

Hi [NAME], just a note that invoice [NUMBER] ([AMOUNT]) is due today. Here's the link again: [LINK]. If you've already paid, thank you, and please ignore this.

C. GENTLE NUDGE (7 DAYS OVERDUE)

Subject: Invoice [NUMBER]: now overdue

Hi [NAME], I haven't seen payment for invoice [NUMBER] ([AMOUNT], due [DATE]) yet. Could you let me know when it's scheduled? If anything on the invoice needs correcting, tell me and I'll fix it right away. [LINK]

D. FIRM FOLLOW-UP (14 DAYS OVERDUE)

Subject: Invoice [NUMBER] is 14 days overdue

Hi [NAME], invoice [NUMBER] for [AMOUNT] is now 14 days past its due date of [DATE]. Please arrange payment by [NEW DATE]. If there's a cash-flow issue, reply and we can agree a short payment plan. [LINK]

E. FINAL NOTICE (30 DAYS OVERDUE)

Subject: Final notice: invoice [NUMBER]

Hi [NAME], this is a final reminder that invoice [NUMBER] for [AMOUNT], due [DATE], remains unpaid despite earlier reminders. Please pay by [FINAL DATE]. As set out in our agreement, [NEXT STEP FROM YOUR AGREEMENT, e.g., "work is paused until the balance is cleared"]. I'd much rather resolve this directly, so please get in touch today.

PAY-02 · PAYMENT REMINDER SEQUENCE PERSONALIZER

I need to send a payment reminder. Context (redacted): client relationship [NEW / LONG-TERM / DIFFICULT], invoice [NUMBER] for [AMOUNT], due [DATE], currently [X] days overdue, previous reminders sent: [LIST]. My agreement says: ""[RELEVANT TERMS]"". Draft the next reminder at stage [A/B/C/D/E]. Keep the tone [FRIENDLY / FIRM / FORMAL] and under 120 words, in my voice [VOICE PROFILE]. Only mention fees or consequences that appear in my agreement text. Include the payment link placeholder [LINK].

WORKFLOW 5 CHECKLIST

- ☐ Payment terms written into my agreement template
- ☐ Deposit policy decided
- ☐ Five reminder templates saved (A–E)
- ☐ Invoice tracker with due dates and "days overdue"
- ☐ Reminders reviewed every week during the admin review (Chapter 13)

Workflow 6: Offboarding, testimonials and referrals

IN THIS CHAPTER

Finish projects in a way that makes clients want to come back and refer you: a clean handover, a specific testimonial request, and a scheduled check-in.

OFFBOARDING CHECKLIST

- ☐ Final deliverables sent, with a short handover document
- ☐ Access transferred or removed (logins, shared folders, tools)
- ☐ Final invoice sent; payment confirmed
- ☐ Thank-you email with what to do if they need help later
- ☐ Testimonial requested (with permission to publish)
- ☐ Referral ask (optional, only if the project went well)
- ☐ Files archived; tracker stage = Past client
- ☐ 90-day check-in date added to the tracker

Ask for a testimonial that's actually useful

Generic requests get generic replies ("Great to work with!"). Specific questions help clients write something honest and useful, and they make it easier for them to say yes.

RET-02 · TESTIMONIAL REQUEST WITH SPECIFIC QUESTIONS

Draft a short email asking a client for a testimonial after we finished [PROJECT]. Make it easy: offer 3 optional questions (What was the situation before? What was it like working together? What changed afterwards?); say it can be 2-3 sentences; ask permission to publish it with their name and business (or anonymously, their choice); and say I'll send them the final wording to approve before it appears anywhere. Under 140 words, in my voice [VOICE PROFILE].

KEEP TESTIMONIALS HONEST

Publish testimonials only with permission, don't edit them in a way that changes their meaning, and never write or invent one. In the U.S., the FTC's Endorsement Guides require endorsements to reflect the honest opinions of the endorser.^[11]

The 90-day check-in

A short, no-pressure email three months after a project ends ("How's the new site working for you? Anything you need?") is one of the simplest ways to earn repeat work and referrals. Add the date to your tracker when you close the project.

Build your SOP library

IN THIS CHAPTER

Standard operating procedures (SOPs) aren't just for big companies. In a business of one, an SOP is a note to your future self, and later to any assistant or contractor you hire.

What a good solo SOP looks like

SOP TEMPLATE

SOP name: [e.g., Onboard a new client] **Purpose:** [why this exists, in one sentence] **Trigger:** [what starts it, e.g., "Client accepts proposal"] **Time:** [typical minutes] **Tools & templates:** [links]
Steps: [numbered, each starting with a verb] **Done when:** [the visible finish line] **Common mistakes:** [what to watch for] **Last reviewed:** [date]

The "do it once, narrate it" method

1. Next time you do the task, keep a notes document open and jot each step as you go (or record a voice memo).
2. Paste the rough notes into your assistant with the prompt below.
3. Edit the result, save it, and link it from your tracker or task app.

OPS-01 • SOP FROM ROUGH NOTES

Turn my rough notes into an SOP using this template: SOP name, Purpose, Trigger, Time, Tools & templates, Steps (numbered, each starting with a verb, max 12), Done when, Common mistakes, Last reviewed [TODAY'S DATE]. Notes: ""[NOTES]"". Keep my exact tool names and links. Where a step is unclear or seems to be missing, add [CHECK: question] instead of guessing.

Your first five SOPs

1. Onboard a new client (Chapter 7 checklist → SOP)
2. Send the weekly update (Chapter 8)
3. Invoice and follow up (Chapter 9)
4. Offboard a client (Chapter 10)
5. Weekly admin review (Chapter 13)

Light automation without new subscriptions

IN THIS CHAPTER

When (and when not) to automate, what you can do with tools you already have, and three simple "recipes".

Four questions before you automate anything

1. **Is the task already templated and working manually?** If not, fix that first.
2. **Does it happen at least weekly?** Rare tasks rarely repay the setup time.
3. **Is it rule-based?** "When X happens, do Y" works; "use judgment" doesn't.
4. **What happens if it fails silently?** If the answer is "a client is upset" or "I lose money", add a check or keep it manual.

Use what you already have

Need	Tools you probably already have
Reusable email replies	Gmail templates, Outlook "My Templates"/Quick Parts, Apple Mail stationery, text expanders
Booking calls without back-and-forth	Booking features in your calendar app, or a free scheduling tool tier
Collecting intake info	Google Forms (responses can go straight into a Google Sheet), Microsoft Forms
Reminders	Calendar events or task-app due dates linked to your tracker's "next action date"
Invoice reminders	Many invoicing tools can send automatic reminders; check yours before building anything

Three starter recipes

RECIPE 1: INQUIRY FORM → SHEET → CONFIRMATION

Trigger: someone submits your website's inquiry form. **Steps:** response lands in a spreadsheet (native with Google Forms) → you get a notification → an auto-reply confirms receipt and shares your booking link. **Cost:** \$0 with native form tools; a free automation tier if you need the auto-reply. **Human step:** you still send the personalized reply (Workflow 1) within one business day.

RECIPE 2: PROPOSAL FOLLOW-UPS THAT NEVER SLIP

Trigger: you mark a proposal as sent in your tracker. **Steps:** set "next action date" to +3 days; your weekly review filters by this column; send the follow-up template. **Cost:** \$0. *The Client Desk* does the date math for you.

RECIPE 3: THE FRIDAY UPDATE HABIT

Trigger: a recurring calendar event every Friday at 3 pm. **Steps:** open notes → run the weekly update prompt (DEL-01) per client → edit → send. **Cost:** \$0. This isn't automation, but it removes the decision of *when*.

What not to automate

- Anything that sends messages to clients **without you reviewing them**, such as AI-written emails going out automatically.
- Anything that makes financial commitments or applies fees automatically, unless your agreement is explicit.
- Conversations that need empathy: bad news, complaints, pricing negotiations.

The weekly admin review

IN THIS CHAPTER

One 45-minute appointment with yourself each week keeps the whole system running and stops admin from leaking into every day.

The agenda

Block	Minutes	What you do
1. Clear the decks	10	Process inbox and messages; capture tasks into your tracker
2. Pipeline	10	Check every client's stage and next-action date; send due follow-ups
3. Money	10	Invoices to send; reminders due (stages A–E); payments to record
4. Next week	10	Block time for client work and deadlines; prepare update notes
5. Improve one thing	5	Turn one annoying task into a template, SOP or prompt

OPS-05 • WEEKLY ADMIN REVIEW ASSISTANT

Act as my weekly admin review assistant. I'll paste: my client tracker rows (redacted), my open invoices with due dates, and my calendar for next week. Produce: (1) follow-ups due this week, with the template to use; (2) invoice actions by reminder stage; (3) risks (overdue items, client dependencies, deadline clashes); (4) a suggested time-block plan for next week; (5) one improvement to my admin system based on patterns you notice. Ask me questions if something is unclear. Data: ""[PASTE]""

Track four numbers

Keep it light. Once a month, note:

1. **Hours on admin this week** (a rough estimate is fine)
2. **Overdue invoices** (count and total)
3. **Average time to first reply** on new inquiries
4. **Proposals sent vs. accepted**

Watching these over two or three months tells you whether the system is working far better than any promise could.

Your next seven days

You now have the whole system. Here's how to put it in place without disrupting client work, about 25–35 minutes a day.

Day	Do this	Output
1	Admin audit (Chapter 2)	Top three tasks to fix
2	Privacy settings, business brief, voice profile (Chapter 3)	Two reusable documents
3	Onboarding checklist + welcome email (Chapter 7)	Onboarding ready for the next client
4	Weekly update template + meeting-summary prompt (Chapter 8)	First five-minute update sent
5	Payment terms + reminder templates (Chapter 9)	All open invoices on a cadence
6	Inquiry reply + proposal structure (Chapters 5–6)	Faster replies and proposals
7	First SOP + first weekly review (Chapters 11 & 13)	The habit that keeps it all running

A final word

The goal isn't a business that runs itself. It's a business where admin is **predictable**: you know what needs doing, you have a good first draft ready, and you spend your best hours on the work only you can do. Start with the highest-scoring task from your audit, get one workflow running well, and build from there.

Thanks for reading. If this playbook helped, we'd genuinely appreciate hearing what worked and what didn't. Feedback shapes every future update.

Appendix A: Prompt index

Every prompt in this book, with its ID in *The Band of One Prompt Library* (which expands each one with variations, example inputs and output formats).

ID	Prompt	Chapter	Use it to
SET-01	Business brief builder	3	Create the one-page context you reuse in every prompt
SET-02	Voice profile from writing samples	3	Make drafts sound like you
SET-03	Redaction check before pasting	3	Catch client details before sharing text with AI
LEAD-01	Reply to a new inquiry	5	Answer inquiries in minutes
DISC-02	Discovery call prep sheet	5	Walk into calls prepared
DISC-05	Call notes → summary + next steps email	5	Follow up the same day
PROP-01	Proposal draft from discovery notes	6	Draft a 7-part proposal
PROP-06	Scope exclusions & assumptions list	6	Prevent scope creep
ONB-01	Welcome email	7	Start projects smoothly
ONB-03	Intake questionnaire builder	7	Collect the right information once
DEL-01	Weekly client update	8	Five-minute updates
DEL-04	Meeting notes → summary & action items	8	Turn calls into clear next steps
DEL-07	Scope change request email	8	Quote extra work without awkwardness
PAY-02	Payment reminder sequence personalizer	9	Send the right reminder at the right stage
RET-02	Testimonial request with specific questions	10	Get useful, honest testimonials
OPS-01	SOP from rough notes	11	Document a process in minutes
OPS-05	Weekly admin review assistant	13	Run your weekly review faster

Appendix B: The system on one page

MY BAND OF ONE ADMIN SYSTEM

Fill this in as you implement each chapter, then keep it somewhere you'll see it.

Part of the system	Where it lives (link or location)	Done?
Admin audit (top 3 tasks)		
Business brief		
Voice profile		
Client tracker		
Inquiry reply template		
Booking link		
Proposal template + exclusions list		
Agreement template (professionally reviewed)		
Onboarding checklist + welcome email		
Intake questionnaire form		
Weekly update template		
Reminder templates A–E		
Offboarding checklist + testimonial request		
SOP folder		
Weekly review time (day & time)		

My weekly review is on: ____ at ____

The one number I'll watch most closely this quarter:

Appendix C: Weekly review worksheet

WEEK OF _____

Print this page or copy it into your notes app each week.

Block	Notes
1. Inbox cleared? Tasks captured?	
2. Follow-ups due (who / which template)	
3. Invoices to send	
3. Reminders due (stage A-E)	
4. Next week's deadlines & time blocks	
5. One thing I'll improve	

This week's numbers: admin hours __ · overdue invoices _ · avg. *first-reply time* · *proposals sent/won*

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All web sources were accessed on 24 September 2026. Tool features and prices change; check the current page before relying on a specific limit.

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How this book was made: This playbook was researched and drafted with AI assistance and edited against a written quality checklist. Statistics are cited with sources and dates. The example business ("Sam") is fictional and used for illustration only; no testimonials or results in this book are real customer claims.

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